

New Generation English B· Diagnostic Test

B2 (Upper-Intermediate Exam Route) B· Listening

LISTENING

Radio segment: City Watch on the Paris case

Script:

Welcome back to City Watch. Today we are looking at Paris, which has been trying for nearly a decade to follow the Amsterdam model. The story is more nuanced than the headlines suggest.

Since 2014, Paris has built over 1,000 kilometres of cycle lanes, reduced car access in the city centre and expanded public squares. Critics often note that progress has been slower and messier than in Amsterdam. They are right, but they often miss the most important difference: Paris started from a much higher car density and a much wider street layout, both designed for traffic.

What surprised urban planners was not the resistance — every transformation produces resistance — but the speed at which behaviour shifted once infrastructure was provided. Within two years of opening protected lanes, cycling among women and older residents tripled. These are the groups that usually avoid cycling in unsafe conditions, so their participation is a strong indicator of real safety.

However, Paris has also revealed the limits of the Amsterdam model. Long suburban commutes still depend on cars. Many delivery vehicles cannot easily be replaced. The mayor's office has had to invest heavily in cargo bikes, electric vans and shared bike systems just to support what was previously taken for granted.

The lesson is not that Paris is failing or succeeding. It is that urban change is slow, expensive and political — and that no city can simply import another city's success.

1. How long has Paris been trying to follow the Amsterdam model?

- A) Nearly a decade.**
- B) Almost fifty years.
- C) Just three years.

2. How many kilometres of cycle lanes has Paris built since 2014?

- A) Over 100.
- B) Over 1,000.**
- C) Over 10,000.

3. What is the most important difference with Amsterdam?

- A) The climate.
- B) Higher car density and wider streets designed for traffic.**
- C) Tourism levels.

4. What surprised urban planners?

- A) The resistance.

B) The speed at which behaviour shifted once infrastructure was provided.

- C) The cost.

5. Which group tripled its cycling within two years?

- A) Tourists.

B) Women and older residents.

- C) Teenagers only.

6. Why is the participation of those groups a strong indicator?

A) They usually avoid cycling in unsafe conditions.

- B) They have more money.

- C) They live in the city centre.

7. What still depends mostly on cars?

- A) School trips.

B) Long suburban commutes.

- C) Tourist sightseeing.

8. What is the central lesson of the segment?

- A) Paris has failed.

- B) Every city should copy Amsterdam.

C) Urban change is slow, expensive and political.